

Peak-End Rule

What is it?

People judge the whole experience based on its most intense moments and how it ends — not on every moment equally.

History

First introduced by Daniel Kahneman and Barbara Fredrickson in **1993**, showing that memory is shaped mostly by the peak intensity and the final moment of an experience.

The Psychology Behind It

- People do not recall experiences as a full timeline
- Memory compresses into: strongest moment (peak) + ending
- One bad peak or bad ending can overshadow everything good
- One powerful peak or pleasant finish can turn an average experience into a memorable one

Why It Matters

- Wrong conclusions about the whole experience
- Poor decisions based on emotional memory
- Misalignment between experience and user perception

How to Apply It

- Create intentional positive peak moments (discounts, delight interactions)
- End flows with strong emotional closers (thank you notes, small reward)
- Reduce negative friction at high-impact touchpoints (errors, delays, loading times)

Theory in Action

- IKEA bought TaskRabbit so users can outsource assembly stress, reducing negative peak
- IKEA cafés add a positive emotional end to the shopping journey (ice cream, hot dogs)

Final Thought

Users remember moments, not averages.

Design the peak and final moment intentionally — those two define how the entire experience will be remembered.

